2021 and the 100th anniversary of the founding of the PRC in 2049. While 2021 was to see China achieve the status of a moderately prosperous country which had banished extreme poverty, 2049 would see the country emerge as a fully developed and advanced socialist nation. Its narrative is simple but powerful in its symbolism. It is inherently nationalistic.

Let us briefly look at China's economic trajectory since the Reform and Opening-Up Policy was launched in 1978.

This strategy marks the beginning of the extraordinary transformation of China from a poor, developing country into an economic powerhouse in just under four decades, lifting 300 million Chinese from poverty. Per capita income rose from US$100 per annum just after the Cultural Revolution in 1976 to the current level of US$10,000. This is unprecedented in economic history, and most of the credit for this success goes to Deng Xiaoping's bold, pragmatic and unconventional leadership.

What were some of the key elements that distinguish Deng's approach to China's development strategy?

Deng's pragmatism lay in adopting policies that were result oriented rather than ideologically prescriptive. He is credited with the dictum 'It does not matter if a cat is black or white as long as it catches mice'. The same pragmatism was evident in his willingness to experiment and innovate but through cautious and careful steps. Thus, he also advocated 'crossing the river by feeling the stones'. Caution was born out of a need to ensure political stability, and without undermining the undisputed authority of the one-party state. Deng acknowledged that China had fallen well behind the advanced economies of the world, and the first requirement of reform was to improve China's human resources through revival of education and by reaching out for knowledge and skills wherever these could be accessed. In 1977 itself, soon after his second political rehabilitation, Deng took on the responsibility for education and science and technology. One of his first major decisions was to reopen China's universities, which had remained shut during the ten chaotic years of the Cultural Revolution. Entrance examinations were reinstated and the politically rehabilitated faculty were given the freedom to design courses that could support China's